

THE BARD

CLASS HANDBOOK



Music, Magic, and Mischief!

Do you love to perform, tell jokes, and be the center of attention? The Bard is a magical musician or storyteller who uses their art to cast spells. You can heal your friends with a beautiful song, or insult a goblin so badly that it actually takes magic damage!



CLASS MECHANICS

BARDIC INSPIRATION

You can use a Bonus Action to give a friend a magical boost! You hand them a **Bardic Inspiration die** (usually a d6 to start). Within the next 10 minutes, when they roll a d20 for an attack, ability check, or saving throw, they can roll your special die and add it to their total. You literally cheer them on to victory!

SPELLCASTING

Bards are full spellcasters! You use your **Charisma** to cast spells. Your magic is focused on charming people, creating illusions, and healing. Instead of a magic wand, you can use a musical instrument (like a lute or a flute) to cast your spells!

JACK OF ALL TRADES

Bards pick up a lot of random skills while traveling. You get to add half of your Proficiency Bonus to any ability check that you aren't already proficient in. You're a little bit good at everything!

STRENGTHS

- **Amazing Support:** You make everyone else in the party better with your Inspiration and healing magic.
- **Skill Master:** You are good at almost every skill, especially talking to people (Persuasion, Deception).
- **Versatile Magic:** You have a great mix of offensive, defensive, and tricky spells.

WEAKNESSES

- **Squishy:** You only wear light armor and don't have a lot of Hit Points. Keep your distance from big monsters!
- **Not a Heavy Hitter:** While you can do damage, you won't hit as hard with a sword as a Fighter or Barbarian.

LEVELING UP (LEVELS 1-5)

As you go on adventures and tell epic stories, you earn Experience Points (XP). When you get enough XP, you level up! Here is what you get as your magic grows:

LEVEL	NEW POWERS!
Level 1	Spellcasting & Bardic Inspiration: You start with your magic spells and your d6 Inspiration dice to cheer on your friends!
Level 2	Jack of All Trades & Song of Rest: You become a little bit good at every skill! Also, when your party takes a short rest, your soothing music helps everyone heal extra Hit Points.
Level 3	Bard College & Expertise: You pick your subclass (see next page)! You also choose two of your skills to get "Expertise," making you incredibly good at them (like super-persuasion or super-stealth).
Level 4	Ability Score Improvement: You get more charming! You can add +2 to one of your stats (like Charisma or Dexterity) or +1 to two different stats.
Level 5	Font of Inspiration: Your Inspiration dice get bigger (they turn into d8s)! Plus, you get all your Inspiration dice back after a short rest, so you can cheer on your friends way more often.

SUBCLASSES (BARD COLLEGES)

At Level 3, Bards join a "College" to specialize in a specific type of performance and magic. Here are two awesome, fun choices:

COLLEGE OF VALOR

You are a battle-bard! You sing epic songs of ancient heroes while fighting right alongside the warriors.

- **Combat Training:** You learn how to wear medium armor, use shields, and fight with cool weapons like longswords and battleaxes!
- **Combat Inspiration:** Your friends can use your Bardic Inspiration to hit enemies harder (adding the die to their damage) or to dodge attacks (adding the die to their Armor Class)!

Pick this if you want to be a magical knight who fights with a sword in one hand and a horn in the other!

COLLEGE OF LORE

You are a collector of secrets, stories, and magic from all over the world. You know a little bit about everything!

- **Bonus Proficiencies:** You get to pick three more skills to be good at. You are the ultimate know-it-all!
- **Cutting Words:** You can use your reaction to magically insult or distract an enemy right when they attack, making them miss!
- **Additional Magical Secrets (at Level 6):** You can steal spells from OTHER classes! Want a Wizard's fireball or a Cleric's super-heal? You can learn it!

Pick this if you want to be a master of magic, skills, and clever insults!

GEAR & STRATEGY

CHOOSING YOUR GEAR

Bards travel light, but they carry the most important tools for adventure:

- **Your Instrument:** This is your magical focus! Will you play a lute, a flute, a drum, or maybe a set of bagpipes?
- **Light Armor:** Leather armor keeps you quick on your feet so you can dodge attacks.
- **A Rapier or Rapier:** A quick, elegant sword is perfect for a Bard. You can also carry a light crossbow to shoot from a safe distance!

HOW TO FIGHT LIKE A BARD

Your job is to make your team amazing and make the enemies look silly!

1. **Stay Safe:** You don't have a lot of health. Stand behind the Fighter or Barbarian and cast your spells from a distance.
2. **Hand Out Inspiration:** Use your Bonus Action to give Bardic Inspiration to the friend who needs to make a big attack or a tough saving throw.
3. **Control the Battlefield:** Use spells like *Sleep* or *Tasha's Hideous Laughter* to stop enemies from attacking. A sleeping goblin is a harmless goblin!

ROLEPLAYING YOUR BARD

WHO ARE YOU?

Bards are the life of the party! Think about what kind of performer you are:

- Are you a famous rockstar looking for new fans, or a humble storyteller collecting ancient myths?
- What is your favorite instrument? Do you sing, dance, juggle, or do magic tricks?
- Why are you adventuring? To write the greatest epic poem ever? To find a magical lute? Or just to get rich and famous?

HOW TO ACT

You are the "Face" of the group. When it's time to talk, you step up to the microphone!

- **Do the Talking:** With your high Charisma, you are the best at persuading guards, haggling with shopkeepers, or calming down angry kings.
- **Be Dramatic:** Describe your magic! Don't just say "I cast a spell." Say "I strum a fiery chord on my lute and sparks fly from the strings!"
- **Keep Spirits High:** When the party is sad or scared, tell a joke, sing a song, or remind them of the great heroes of the past. You are their cheerleader!

"Why use a sword when a perfectly timed joke can hurt them just as much? Plus, the joke doesn't need sharpening!"

LEVELING UP (LEVELS 6-10)

Your magic is getting stronger and your songs are getting catchier! Here is what happens as your Bard reaches level 10:

LEVEL	NEW POWERS!
Level 6	Countercharm & Subclass Feature: You can use your music to protect your friends from being frightened or charmed! You also get a cool new power from your Bard College.
Level 7	4th-Level Spells: You unlock super powerful spells! You can now cast <i>Polymorph</i> to turn a big scary monster into a harmless little turtle!
Level 8	Ability Score Improvement: Add +2 to one stat or +1 to two different stats to become even more charming!
Level 9	Song of Rest Upgrade & 5th-Level Spells: Your relaxing song heals even more during short rests. Plus, you unlock amazing spells like <i>Greater Restoration</i> !
Level 10	Magical Secrets: This is the best Bard power! You can choose TWO spells from ANY other class (like a Wizard's <i>Fireball</i> or a Paladin's healing magic) and learn them forever! You also get Expertise in two more skills!

FAMOUS HEROES & LEGENDS

Throughout history, many musical Bards have become legends. Which of these heroes sounds most like you?

FINNIAN THE LUTE-SMASHER

Finnian didn't just play his magic lute; he rocked out! During a fight with an evil wizard, Finnian played a magical chord so loud that it shattered all the windows in the castle, and then he smashed his lute over the wizard's head to finish the fight!

PIPER THE STORY-WEAVER

Piper could tell stories that actually came to life. Once, when surrounded by hungry trolls, she told a story about a massive feast. The trolls were so tricked by her magical words that they sat down to eat imaginary food while Piper and her friends tiptoed away!

BEST MAGIC ITEMS

If you find a treasure chest, look for these awesome magic items! They are perfect for a Bard:

- **Instrument of the Bards:** These are legendary magic instruments (like a special mandolin or harp). They make your spells harder to resist and let you cast extra spells like *Invisibility* or *Fly* for free!
- **Cape of the Mountebank:** A fabulous, sparkly cape that lets you cast the *Dimension Door* spell once a day. You step into a puff of pink smoke and teleport up to 500 feet away!
- **Rhythm-Maker's Drum:** A magical drum that makes your spellcasting stronger and helps you get your Bardic Inspiration dice back faster.
- **Hat of Disguise:** A stylish hat that lets you change what you look like at any time. You can trick guards into thinking you are the king!

COMBAT CHEAT SHEET

What should you do on your turn? Use this quick guide to remember your options!

ACTION

Choose one big thing to do:

- **Cast a Spell:** This is your main job! Cast a spell to hurt bad guys, help your friends, or change the battlefield.
- **Attack:** Swing your rapier or shoot your crossbow if you don't want to use a spell slot.
- **Hide or Dodge:** If you are low on health, hide behind a rock or focus on dodging!

BONUS ACTION

Choose one quick thing to do (if you have one):

- **Bardic Inspiration!:** Give a magical d6 (or d8) die to a friend so they can add it to their roll. Always try to keep your friends inspired!
- **Healing Word:** Cast this quick spell to heal a friend from far away!

REACTION

A quick move when it's NOT your turn:

- **Cutting Words (Lore Bard):** If an enemy is about to hit your friend, insult them so badly that they miss!
- **Opportunity Attack:** Smack an enemy who tries to run past you.

DRAW YOUR HERO!

What does your musical Bard look like? Draw them here!

- **What is their name?**

- **What is their favorite instrument?**

- **What is their best joke?**

